MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 4: The Way of the World - William Congreve

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Congreve’s The Way of the World uses wit and intrigue to examine how marriage connects affection, independence, reputation, and property.

Start with a picture

Two people negotiate not only whether to marry but how to keep a self within marriage. Around them, relatives and rivals calculate who controls the money. Conversation becomes a contest over the rules of living together.

1. Main relationships

Mirabell and Millamant wish to marry, but financial arrangements and Lady Wishfort’s approval complicate their position. Fainall, Mrs Fainall, and Mrs Marwood bring other forms of desire, deception, and economic power into the plot.

The servants Waitwell and Foible help Mirabell’s scheme. Social rank does not prevent the household from depending on their action and knowledge.

2. Intrigue and disguise

Waitwell’s assumed identity as Sir Rowland is intended to draw Lady Wishfort into a compromising situation. The scheme reveals the relation between romantic hope, social performance, and vulnerability.

A summary must keep the scheme distinct from the later legal means through which coercion is resisted. Not every resolution comes from clever speech alone.

3. The proviso scene

Mirabell and Millamant discuss conditions for marriage. Their verbal negotiation gives independence a place inside a relationship that law and custom often structure unequally.

Wit can show intimacy and intelligence, but it also marks social competence. Ask what choices each person actually possesses and what depends on property or family permission.

4. Fainall’s coercion

Fainall tries to use marriage, reputation, and financial dependence for advantage. Documents protecting Mrs Fainall’s property become important to defeating his demands. The play connects law with social power rather than imagining that love escapes economic conditions.

5. Comedy of manners

The language of fashionable society becomes both an object of satire and a source of audience pleasure. Irony, repartee, hidden motives, and calculated appearances organise the action.

Repartee is quick verbal exchange; **proviso** is a stated condition. Use the terms to explain an interaction, not simply to praise cleverness.

6. Reading the ending

The comic resolution allows desired arrangements to become possible. It does not prove that wit has removed every inequality from the world. An interpretation should consider what the ending protects and the resources needed to achieve that protection.

Quick check

1. Is marriage treated as only private affection? **No; money and law are central.**
2. What does the proviso scene make visible? **Negotiation over intimacy and autonomy.**
3. Is a legal document irrelevant to comedy? **No; it can determine the ending’s possibilities.**

Build an exam answer

1. Establish marriage’s economic and social conditions.
2. Explain the intrigue and household relationships.
3. Analyse the proviso scene closely.
4. Discuss Fainall and the protective documents.
5. Evaluate what the ending secures and leaves intact.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not treat the play as a simple celebration of romantic freedom or confuse witty dialogue with equal power.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Discuss the relationship between wit, autonomy, and property in The Way of the World.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The play’s wit is inseparable from a social world in which marriage organises resources and authority. Mirabell and Millamant’s desired union depends not only on mutual attraction but on permissions and financial arrangements. Their clever conversation is therefore a means of negotiating conditions, not an escape from conditions altogether.

The proviso scene gives this negotiation an especially visible form. Expectations about habits, privacy, and conduct are made discussable before the proposed marriage. A reading can recognise Millamant’s assertion of self while asking how much independence remains secured by class and property. The scene does not demonstrate that early modern marriage has already become fully equal.

Fainall’s manoeuvres expose a harsher use of the same institution. Reputation and financial vulnerability become instruments of pressure. The importance of the protective documents shows that material arrangements can defeat coercion where moral denunciation alone would be insufficient.

A strong answer connects these pressures with the language and staging of intrigue. Comedy exposes the world’s rules while enabling selected characters to navigate them. Its resolution offers a real dramatic correction, but its limits remain part of an adequate account of autonomy.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Consider the play as a Comedy of Manners.
2. How do the characters involve in schemes to inherit wealth?
3. How does the play display the link between love and money?